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RESEARCH ARTICLE



The geography of autocracy. Regime preferences along the rural-urban divide in 32 countries

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ABSTRACT

There is growing concern about a political divide between urban and rural places. Against this background, we evaluate the geography of regime preferences regarding a key aspect of democratic support, e.g. attitudes towards democracy and its authoritarian alternatives. We would like to find out whether possible rural-urban differences are due to different socio-economic situations, differing values or to the degree of political discontent of urbanites and rural dwellers. Using recent European Values Survey data from 32 European countries and over 30,000 respondents from 2017 to 2020, we show that rural residents are more supportive of authoritarian regimes than urban dwellers are. Moreover, our path analyses indicate that socio-economic and cultural differences between urbanites and ruralites are particularly crucial, while the political mechanisms cannot explain the spatial divide of regime preferences.

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KEYWORDS rural-urban divide; democracy; authoritarian rule; comparative analysis; path analysis

Introduction

There is growing concern about a political divide between urban and rural places.¹ Numerous studies demonstrate greater sympathy for right-wing populists, stronger opposition to immigration, less trust in political institutions and greater political dissatisfaction in rural regions than in urban ones.² It seems, that democratic challenges are more pronounced amongst citizens in the rural periphery than amongst their metropolitan counterparts.

This is the starting point of our investigation. In this article, we aim to supplement previous research and evaluate the geography of regime preferences regarding a key aspect of democratic support, e.g. attitudes towards democracy and its authoritarian alternatives.³ Building on key insights of social identity theory⁴, we argue that place provides the basis for a shared place-based social identity. Munis⁵ maintains that “place identity refers to a sense of belonging to a group whose membership is defined by living in a particular place and having a psychological attachment of group-based perception with other group members.” Moreover, people’s

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consciousness of belonging to a group and their psychological bonds to those groups promote the propensity for in-group bias.⁶ In competition-oriented settings such as politics, this kind of in-group bias can lead to animosity towards other groups and to intergroup conflict such as a rural-urban conflict.

With our study we address two primary goals. First, we want to investigate whether a rural-urban divide regarding regime preference exists. With this, we deal with the nitty-gritty: with the backing of democratic principles, which, as a pivotal aspect of diffuse political support are fundamental to the survival of a political system.⁷ Ever since Lipset⁸ and Easton⁹, it is widely believed that democracy requires public support to survive.¹⁰ Second, we aim to uncover the underlying mechanisms of this geographical divide. In general, research on the rural-urban divide agrees on the rural population feeling *left behind* their urban counterparts. This unpleasant feeling is fuelled by three mechanisms: socio-economic, cultural and political. While these paths have been theoretically asserted many times, they have not yet empirically been tested in a well-founded manner, especially not comparatively against one another or in a large number of countries.

The *socio-economic mechanism* follows the idea that people in rural areas are being “left behind” by current processes such as globalization and financial crises. Their socio-economic status worsens due to these challenges, while urban residents profit from them. This widening socio-economic gap leaves rural residents dissatisfied and resentful. They will consequently turn away from the current democratic government that seems unable to properly safeguard their socio-economic status. Instead, rural residents develop a stronger preference for an authoritarian government from which they expect greater protection.¹¹

The second mechanism follows a rural-urban divide with regard to *norms and values*, as it has recently been declared by Kaufmann¹² regarding the 2016 UK Brexit vote. Rural residents adhere to more conservative authoritative and communitarian norms and values, whereas attitudes of urban dwellers are on average more liberal, cosmopolitan, transnational and progressive. Further, culturally conservative people are more open to authoritarian governments, as they might see authoritarian governance as an effective way of upholding their traditional virtues.¹³ Therefore, people in rural areas will exhibit a stronger preference for authoritarian as opposed to democratic governments.

Third, the *political path* follows the idea that the rural population’s feelings of being left behind are mainly due to political reasons. Rural residents feel ignored and marginalized by political decision makers, who seem to be an urban elite only catering to the needs of big cities.¹⁴ This political devaluation gives rise to dissatisfaction with and distrust of democratic institutions and leads to a lower preference for democracies as opposed to autocracies among the rural population.¹⁵

We test these assumptions drawing on individual-level data from the European Values Study (EVS) from 2017 to 2020. The dataset consists of roughly 30,000 observations from 32 countries. We employ multiple regression and path analyses with country-fixed effects. Our analysis shows that, compared to urbanites, respondents living in rural areas indeed exhibit a stronger preference for authoritarian as opposed to democratic governments. Moreover, our path analyses indicate that education, moral values and ethnic conceptions of nationhood are the most crucial mediators. In a nutshell, our analyses show that socio-economic and cultural differences between urbanites and ruralites are particularly crucial, while the political mechanisms cannot explain the spatial divide of regime preferences.

Overall, our study contributes to the literature in several respects. First, despite growing research on the rural-urban divide in elections, policy-attitudes, populism, and political trust, little to no research in this strand of literature has yet explored public preferences for democracy and its authoritarian alternatives, e.g. rule by the army or a strong leader. In this respect, our study goes beyond previous analyses of political trust and populism and adds new nuances to the existing knowledge. In addition, we move beyond the investigation of the mere existence of a spatial divide. Our findings demonstrate the need to unravel the black box of possible mechanisms of the geographical gap to get a more accurate picture of the driving forces behind the rural-urban divide. Since there is growing evidence that spatial marginalization fuels feelings of discontent, we can reveal the deeper roots of this phenomenon. While these roots are by no means original arguments, we test them in a methodologically sound way. Comparing the different arguments via path-analyses, possible indications for bridging the rural-urban divide could be derived. To the best of our knowledge, this kind of analysis has never been carried out. Moreover, unlike most studies that rely on a single country to study the spatial divide with regard to political attitudes, we provide a comparative perspective of the rural-urban divide in 32 European countries to arrive at findings that are more generalizable. Finally, our findings also bear relevant policy implications. To increase support for democracy, it is essential that policymakers know where to start and where democratic support is high or low to begin with. Still, 30 percent of respondents in our European data set live rurally (see Figure A1 in the Supplemental Appendix), a number that is quite relevant against the background of the present results. Accordingly, if there is a geography of democratic support, it is vital to know and understand it.

Background: democratic deconsolidation and democratic support

For democracy to remain “the only game in town”, three factors must be fulfilled: The state’s key actors must reflect democratic norms and practices (constitution), no significant groups should attempt to overthrow the regime (behaviour) and, finally, the overwhelming majority of people should see democracy as the best type of regime (culture).¹⁶ However, even in the most consolidated democracies in Europe, there has been a trend towards less democratic support in recent years. Foa and Mounk¹⁷ coined the term *democratic deconsolidation* to describe this process; a sizable minority of citizens ceasing to believe in democracy and instead preferring authoritarian alternatives.

More than 50 years ago, Lipset¹⁸ and Easton¹⁹ hypothesized that popular support is crucial for democracy. Since then, scholars have widely agreed and empirically demonstrated that popular backing for democratic regimes over their authoritarian alternatives is a pivotal democratic foundation.²⁰ For this reason, democratic support has already received considerable scholarly attention. The roots of regime preference have already been explored in terms of life-cycle and generation effects, socio-economic status, political trust, values, populist attitudes and parties.²¹ It is therefore quite startling, that there is no analysis on the geography of autocracy. We try to start to fill this gap.

Theoretical linkages: the rural-urban divide of democratic support

The rural-urban divide was popularized by the cleavage theory of Lipset and Rokkan²² and emerged at the time of the Industrial Revolution. At that time, a conflict arose

between agricultural and industrial interests. In the last decades of globalization and modernization, the rural-urban divide also emerged in terms of values and attitudes between the winners and losers of globalization and has consequently received increased attention.²³ Today, differences between urban and rural populations can be seen in all kinds of political spheres such as the 2016 and 2020 US elections, and the 2016 Brexit vote, but also in political attitudes, populist party choice as well as political trust.²⁴ However, the rural-urban divide has not yet been examined with regard to democratic support.

The main argument for a rural-urban divide is that the rural population feels as if they were *left behind* the urban population. The prerequisite for this argument are processes of social categorization, social identification, and social comparison.²⁵ People categorize themselves as belonging to a rural area. Through social interactions with the resident individuals, they develop a strong emotional attachment to this geographically bounded place. As shown by various geographers, sociologists, and environmental psychologists, people are connected to the places in which they live, and places operate as the basis for a shared place-based social identity.²⁶ The building of a place-based identity, however, leads to in-group favouritism and is accompanied by an ongoing comparison with out-groups one does not identify with. If the comparisons turn out to be unfavourable on the side of the in-group, animosities towards the out-group can arise and feelings of disadvantage can develop. Regarding the rural-urban divide on the political realm, this translates to less trust in political parties, politicians, and national parliaments by the rural population, compared to their urban counterparts, for example.²⁷

While research on the rural-urban divide agrees that the rural population feels left behind and, therefore, tends to be critical of the political system,²⁸ just what the driving force of this discontent is remains controversial.²⁹ Here, previous studies on the rural-urban divide put forward a socio-economic, a cultural, and a political mechanism.³⁰

The *socio-economic* explanation suggests that rural people, who are often less educated, poorer and with worse employment and mobility opportunities, fear for their socio-economic status.³¹ Recent globalization and modernization developments downsize their manual jobs in traditionally protected sectors, which are to some extent outsourced or taken over by foreign workers. These developments are all the more threatening, because the democratic system with its institutionalized insecurities cannot guarantee that rural people get the “fair share” they believe they deserve.³² In turn, individuals with a lower socio-economic status exhibit lower support for democratic settings and are instead more prone to preferring authoritarian political systems with strong leadership ensuring collective security.³³ Thus, due to their on average lower socio-economic status and because of their unfulfilled economic interests, rural residents should exhibit higher levels of democratic deconsolidation as opposed to urban dwellers.

The *cultural* path follows a more value-based approach.³⁴ While cosmopolitan, liberal, progressive and open-minded values prevail in urban centres, rural residents are inclined to be more traditional, conservative, inward-looking and nostalgic. With the increasing globalization and modernization of society, the more conservative rural population also feels left behind in a cultural sense, while the world is growing ever more progressive.³⁵ That is, while urban dwellers see the changes as an opportunity and welcome the associated possibilities for personal development, rural residents feel that their traditions, identities, values and lifestyles are

threatened by the ongoing modernization. This trend towards an ever-changing, cosmopolitan, transnational, and liberal world is reinforced by democracies. In contrast, authoritarian systems may appear to preserve traditional values and the status quo better than their democratic counterparts. Malka et al.³⁶ find that cultural conservatism is consistently associated with openness to authoritarian governance. Consequently, the more conservative rural population should show a stronger preference for authoritarian regimes than the urban population, mainly because they feel left behind in a cultural sense.

Finally, the *political* mechanism assumes that the rural population feels left behind mainly due to political reasons and that this leads to resentments towards the democratic regime. There are various reasons why the rural population could feel politically marginalized due to where they live. Media representation and political decisions lead them to feel as though politicians are an urban elite that ignores their needs, not recognizing the real problems in rural areas and instead only catering to the needs of big cities.³⁷ Additionally, being physically removed from urban centres where political decisions are made, makes the rural population feel powerless and excluded from political processes.³⁸ These factors contribute to the rural population feeling disadvantaged, and dissatisfied with and distrusting of politics.³⁹ Altogether, these feelings might translate into a decrease in democratic support, e.g. a lower preference for a democratic regime.⁴⁰ Authoritarian alternatives can subsequently appear as more efficacious systems from which the politically forsaken rural population expects to better meet their needs.

Although emphasizing different aspects of feeling left behind, all mechanisms agree that the rural population feels devalued compared to the urban population. This leads to resentment towards the current democratic system and to a stronger preference for an authoritarian regime. The following analysis will show which of the three explanatory paths are decisive in European democracies.

Research design, variables and method

Data and operationalization

In the remainder of the article, we will empirically test the relationships presented above. We use data from the latest wave of the European Values Study from 2017 to 2020.⁴¹ The dataset contains around 30,000 usable observations from 32 different countries.⁴² The respondents were interviewed face to face about various aspects of their lives, society and politics.

Regarding our dependent variable, we follow Erhardt, Wamsler, and Freitag⁴³ and opt for a measure that distinguishes the support of respondents for a democratic regime vis-a-vis authoritarian alternatives.⁴⁴ The EVS asks respondents whether they perceive certain types of political systems to be a good way of governing their country, including (a) a democratic political system, (b) a strong leader who does not have to bother with parliament and elections, and (c) having the army rule the country, with answers ranging from very bad (0) to very good (3). We combine the three items onto a single scale as the average of the three items (with leader rule and army rule reversed, so that higher values indicate a preference for more democratic systems).⁴⁵ The resulting variable ranges from “0” to “3”, with a higher number indicating a stronger preference for democratic rule.

With respect to our main independent variable, urbanity is measured with the size of the town where the interview was conducted. This variable serves as a proxy for the actual place of residence of the respondents.⁴⁶ Population size is one of the most established measures of rurality and urbanity.⁴⁷ The EVS asks for the size of the town with regard to five categories: less than 5,000 inhabitants, 5,000–20,000 inhabitants, 20,000–100,000 inhabitants, 100,000–500,000 inhabitants and more than 500,000 inhabitants. Most respondents (31 percent) live in the smallest category, while around 20 percent of respondents live in the second and third categories each; 16 percent live in the second largest category and about 13 percent live in a town with more than 500,000 inhabitants. We treat these five categories of urbanity as a continuous variable.⁴⁸

With respect to the socio-economic status as our first mediator we follow the current literature on the rural-urban divide and political resentments and rely on variables commonly used to measure a respondent's socio-economic status: education, income and dependency on social security.⁴⁹ Education is operationalized using a 9-level variable measuring the highest educational attainment according to ISCED coding, with a higher number corresponding to a higher level of education. Income is measured using the decile of the net household income. The dependency on social security is a binary variable, which measures whether the respondent relied on social security during the last five years ("0" No; "1" Yes).

The second mediator is cultural. To measure a respondent's values, we rely on a set of items that are used as an expression of a threatened lifestyle and of a (rural) moral community under siege.⁵⁰ Again, we employ three different operationalizations: ethnic conception of nationhood, authoritarianism and a moral values index. Ethnic conception of nationhood is a concept from national identity. It measures the degree to which respondents find ethnic characteristics important for belonging to a nation. Specifically, this is operationalized using the mean of the two items: Whether it is important to be born in a country and whether it is important to have ancestry from that country in order to be part of that nation. The variable runs from "1" (not at all important) to "4" (very important). Authoritarianism is measured with the question of whether it would be good or bad to have greater respect for authority. Respondents could answer this question with good (3), they do not mind (2) or bad (1).⁵¹ Finally, the composite index of moral values consists of four items on moral value questions. Respondents could indicate whether they justify homosexuality, abortion, divorce and euthanasia on a scale from "1" (never) to "10" (always). The mean value of these four items is then taken to build an index of moral values.⁵²

Third, three measures are used to operationalize the political path: satisfaction with the functioning of the political system, trust in parliament and trust in the government. Previous research has shown that these attitudes are important indicators of the feeling of not being heard politically.⁵³ For political satisfaction, respondents could answer on a scale from "1" (not satisfied at all) to "10" (completely satisfied) how satisfied they were with the functioning of the political system. Regarding trust in parliament and trust in the government, respondents declare how much confidence they have in their government and their national parliament on a scale from "1" (none at all) to "4" (a great deal).

Finally, with regard to the controls, we include the respondent's sex ("0" = female, "1" = male), their age in years and their political left-right position on a scale from "1" (left) to "10" (right). We rely on these variables according to the rural-urban literature.⁵⁴

Path analysis

Path analysis is a causal modelling approach and a special case of Structural Equation Modeling (SEM). SEM emerged to go beyond the usual case of one outcome variable and many covariates. Instead, SEM can be used to model more complex model structures in which, for example, direct and indirect effects of an independent variable on a dependent variable are measured. In this case, the exogenous covariate X not only influences Y directly, but is also a covariate for the mediator M , while M is simultaneously a covariate for Y . Thus, X not only has a direct effect on Y , but also an indirect effect via M . This chain of statistical associations is also referred to as *path analysis*.⁵⁵ SEM can also calculate much more complex models, for example with latent variables, but since our models only operate with observed variables, we limit ourselves to a path analysis. Furthermore, all our models are calculated with country fixed effects and robust standard errors using the Huber Sandwich Estimator. Since we are only interested in effects at the individual level and not in national differences of democratic support, we employ contextual fixed-effects. These encompass a dummy for each country, accounting for all between-country variance and ensuring that results are not influenced by any differences between the countries (for example the rate of unemployment, political institutions, cultural heritages, etc.).⁵⁶ Lastly, we do not apply weights, as they are only recommended for single country studies and country comparisons in the EVS. Nevertheless, we re-calculated all models while applying weights and found that the results remained substantially the same (results available upon request).

Results

Before we examine the different mechanisms through which urbanity influences regime preference, we first examine the direct relationship between urbanity and preference for democracies with and without control variables (see models 1 and 2 in Table 1). The respective coefficients of urbanity ($b = 0.035$, $SE = .002$, $p < .01$ in model 1; $b = 0.036$, $SE = .002$, $p < .01$ in model 2) are statistically significant and positive in both models and do not change when control variables are included.⁵⁷ The positive coefficient indicates that the more urban the area is, the stronger the preference for a democratic political system. The effect size of an additional point on the urbanity scale is about 5 percent of the standard deviation of the dependent variable.⁵⁸

As a first step to explore the theoretically introduced mechanisms, we include the socio-economic, cultural and political mediators (see models 3–5). This technique is described as the “difference method”.⁵⁹ We control for so-called post-treatment variables, i.e. mediating variables, assumed to be affected by the treatment (degree of urbanity of the respondent’s environment) and to affect the outcome variable (regime preference). The decreasing size and significance of the coefficients of the urbanity variable after controlling for these mediating variables can be interpreted as an indication of mediation. Model 3 shows that the inclusion of the socio-economic variables almost halves the coefficient of urbanity ($b = 0.019$, $SE = .002$, $p < 0.01$). Model 4 shows that the inclusion of the cultural mediators reduces the coefficient of urbanity by about the same amount ($b = 0.020$, $SE = .002$, $p < 0.01$). As model 5 shows, however, the inclusion of the political variables does not influence the coefficient of urbanity substantially ($b = 0.036$, $SE = .002$, $p < 0.01$). We therefore assume no strong mediating effect of the political variables. Finally, in model 6, we find that the inclusion of all mediators

Table 1. Linear regression analysis.

	Model 1	Model 2	Model 3	Model 4	Model 5	Model 6
Urbanity	0.035*** (0.002)	0.036*** (0.002)	0.019*** (0.002)	0.020*** (0.002)	0.036*** (0.002)	0.011*** (0.002)
Gender (male)		0.011* (0.006)				
Age		0.002*** (0.000)				
Left-right position		−0.021*** (0.001)				
Education			0.048*** (0.002)			0.038*** (0.002)
Income			0.011*** (0.001)			0.006*** (0.001)
Social security			−0.058*** (0.009)			−0.064*** (0.010)
Ethnic nationhood				−0.089*** (0.004)		−0.080*** (0.004)
Authoritarianism				−0.013*** (0.003)		−0.011*** (0.004)
Moral values				0.042*** (0.001)		0.036*** (0.001)
Political satisfaction					0.004*** (0.001)	0.004*** (0.001)
Confidence in parliament					−0.004 (0.004)	−0.003 (0.005)
Confidence in government					−0.012*** (0.004)	0.003 (0.005)
N	44'435	36'902	37'885	39'038	42'246	32'623
R-squared	0.277	0.289	0.307	0.321	0.276	0.342

Note: Standard errors in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. Models are estimated with country fixed effects and robust standard errors.

Source: EVS, "European Values Study 2017", own calculations.

simultaneously reduces the coefficient of urbanity to about a third of its original size ($b = 0.011$, $SE = .002$, $p < 0.01$). This shows that all mediators together can explain a large part of the effect of urbanity on democratic preference.⁶⁰

To further test the role of our mediators we estimate several structural equation models. First, we calculate each of the three mechanisms separately (see tables A2 to A4 in the Supplemental Appendix). Second, structural equation models are estimated for each of the nine mediators alone (see tables A5 to A13 in the Supplemental Appendix). Finally, we conduct a structural equation model with all nine mediators simultaneously. In all models, we control for gender, age and the political left-right positioning of the respondents. The models all contain country fixed effects and are estimated with robust standard errors.

Regarding the socio-economic mechanisms, we find that all three variables together explain about 45 percent (0.015/0.033) of the effect of urbanity on the regime preference (see table A2 in the Supplemental Appendix). The models with only one mediator at a time (tables A5 to A7 in the Supplemental Appendix) reveal that education shows the strongest effect (0.014; $SE = .001$, $p < 0.01$) and explains about 40 percent of the relationship between urbanity and the preference for democratic systems. Thus, people living in urban areas are significantly more educated and these educated people have a significantly stronger preference for democracies as opposed to less educated people living in rural areas. Net household income (0.004, $SE = .000$, $p < 0.01$) is a much weaker mediator and explains only about 12 percent of the total effect.

Nevertheless, this path shows that living in urban areas is associated with a significantly higher income and a higher income is simultaneously linked to a stronger preference for democracies. Dependency on social security, however, is not a significant mediator for the relationship between urbanity and regime preference ($b = -0.000$, $SE = .000$, $p = 0.91$). This is because urbanity and dependency on social security payments are not significantly related, whereas people who were dependent on social security transfers have a significantly lower preference for democracies as opposed to autocracies. Altogether, these findings show that the socio-economic mechanism is pivotal in explaining the relationship between urbanity and preference for democracy, but that it is primarily education and, to a lesser extent, income that mediates the relationship.

Second, with respect to the cultural path model, table A3 in the Supplemental Appendix shows that all included cultural mediators together explain about 40 percent of the effect of urbanity on regime preference (0.015/0.036). In this regard, the cultural path seems a little less relevant than the socio-economic path. Regarding the single mediating variables (tables A8 to A10 in the Supplemental Appendix), we find that ethnic conception of nationhood and moral values are the main mediators. The indirect effect of ethnic conception of nationhood (0.007, $SE = .000$, $p < 0.01$) explains about 20 percent of the total effect. This reveals that people living in urban areas are less inclined to hold an ethnic conception of nationhood. Urban people therefore consider it less important to be born in a country or to have ancestors from a country in order to be part of that nation. At the same time, people with a more ethnic conception of nationhood show a lower preference for democracies as opposed to autocracies. A statistically significant but barely relevant explanatory path emerges via authoritarianism (0.001, $SE = .000$, $p < 0.01$). Authoritarian attitudes only explain about 2 percent of the relationship between urbanity and democratic preferences. Urban residents show less respect for authority than rural residents, and higher levels of authoritarianism are associated with a stronger preference for autocracies as opposed to democratic political systems. Finally, moral values are the most important cultural mediator (0.009, $SE = .001$, $p < 0.01$) and explain 26 percent of the relationship between urbanity and regime preference.⁶¹ While urban residents tend to exhibit more modern moral values, people with more modern moral values have a stronger preference for democratic political systems.

Third, with respect to the political mediators (satisfaction with the functioning of the political system, trust in parliament and in the government), model A4 in the Supplemental Appendix shows that this mechanism explains only about 1 percent of the total effect of urbanity on regime preference (0.0002/0.037). As opposed to the socio-economic and cultural mechanisms, political mediation seems to be irrelevant in explaining the relationship between living in urban areas and democratic preference. While the indirect effects of urbanity on democratic preference via political satisfaction (-0.000 , $SE = .000$, $p = 0.45$) and trust in parliament ($b = 0.000$, $SE = 0.000$, $p = 0.45$) are statistically not significant, the indirect effect through trust in government, though statistically significant (0.000, $SE = .000$, $p < .10$), fails to be relevant (see tables A11 to A13 in the Supplemental Appendix).

Finally, we estimate a structural equation model including all nine mediators simultaneously (see Table 2). It turns out that of the socio-economic variables, education in particular, still reveals a strong effect ($b = 0.010$, $SE = .001$, $p < 0.01$). About 29 percent of the effect of urbanity on democratic preference can be explained through this mediation. Among the cultural variables, moral values ($b = 0.007$, $SE = .000$, $p < 0.01$)

Table 2. SEM with all mediators.

	Coefficient	Robust S.E.	% of TE explained
Total effect	0.035***	(0.002)	
Direct effect (urbanity → system preference)	0.011***	(0.002)	30.31%
Mediation via			
– education:			
Indirect effect	0.010***	(0.001)	28.99%
urbanity → education	0.249***	(0.008)	
education → system preference	0.040***	(0.002)	
– income:			
Indirect effect	0.002**	(0.000)	4.59%
urbanity → income	0.163***	(0.012)	
income → system preference	0.010***	(0.001)	
– social security:			
Indirect effect	–0.000	(0.000)	–0.14%
urbanity → social security	0.001	(0.001)	
social security → system preference	–0.049***	(0.011)	
– ethnic nationhood:			
Indirect effect	0.005***	(0.000)	15.59%
urbanity → ethnic nationhood	–0.062***	(0.004)	
ethnic nationhood → system preference	–0.088***	(0.004)	
– authoritarianism:			
Indirect effect	0.000**	(0.000)	0.65%
urbanity → authoritarianism	–0.027***	(0.004)	
authoritarianism → system preference	–0.008**	(0.004)	
– moral values:			
Indirect effect	0.007***	(0.000)	19.94%
urbanity → moral values	0.172***	(0.010)	
moral values → system preference	0.040***	(0.002)	
– political satisfaction:			
Indirect effect	–0.000	(0.000)	–0.02%
urbanity → political satisfaction	–0.001	(0.011)	
political satisfaction → system preference	0.006***	(0.002)	
– confidence in parliament:			
Indirect effect	0.000	(0.000)	0.01%
urbanity → confidence in parliament	–0.002	(0.004)	
confidence in parliament → system preference	–0.002	(0.005)	
– confidence in government:			
Indirect effect	0.000	(0.000)	0.10%
urbanity → confidence in government	–0.017***	(0.004)	
confidence in government → system preference	–0.002	(0.005)	
Observations	28'559		

Note: Models are estimated with country fixed effects and robust standard errors.

Example: The total effect of urbanity on democratic preference is 0.035. The direct effect, after controlling for all mediators, is 0.011. This means that 0.024 (0.035–0.011) (about 60%, 0.024/0.035) of the total effect can be explained through our mediators. The indirect effect running through a mediator is calculated by multiplying the effect of urbanity on this mediator with the effect of the mediator on democratic preference.

Source: EVS, “European Values Study 2017”, own calculations.

explain about 20 percent of the total effect, while ethnic conception of nationhood ($b = 0.005$, $SE = .000$, $p < 0.01$) mediates 16 percent of the relationship between urbanity and regime preference. All other mediators contribute little to the decomposition of the analysed relationship in this model. Nevertheless, the various mechanisms mediate about 70 percent of the total effect of urbanity on democratic preference (0.024/0.036).⁶²

Discussion

Our study exposes multiple paths to explain why the rural-urban divide translates into regime preferences in comparative perspective. It is astonishing that not only socio-

economic differences between urban and rural areas are important, but rather a combination of socio-economic and cultural differences, while political differences hold no explanatory power whatsoever. That is, cultural inequalities between urban and rural areas are just as important as socio-economic differences. It is not only socio-economic marginalization that makes rural residents turn away from democracy; the perceived loss of traditional values is equally relevant as to why rural dwellers seek salvation in authoritarian systems. Against this background, it seems imperative to look at all possible paths that lead to the rural population feeling left behind by urbanites.

If the rural-urban divide in terms of regime preference is to be overcome, the key lies in education policy, which in itself explains about 40 percent of the rural-urban divide in democratic support. Increased public investment in education and training in rural areas could ensure that the proportion of low-educated people in these areas declines. In addition, this could be linked to the hope that rural residents will be freed from their fears of cultural decay if they expand their horizons and become more open to change. Those who already accept change have less of a problem accepting democracies. Change, again, is the lifeblood of democracies.

However, even though our analyses show that there is a rural-urban divide in democratic support, which can be explained through socio-economic and cultural differences, we cannot make any causal claims about these differences between ruralites and urbanites. Debates about geographical disparities usually emphasize two explanations: compositional effects and contextual effects.⁶³ Compositional effects suggest that people who move into urban or rural areas are different from one another, for example in their education, income or values. Based on these characteristics, they self-sort into the place that is most suitable to their lifestyle and worldviews. This then leads to different compositions of rural and urban places and accounts for aggregated rural-urban differences in attitudes and behaviour. Contextual effects, on the other hand, assume that distinct experiences in rural and urban contexts create differences between people living in or moving into these two areas.⁶⁴ Even though studies try to conceptually separate these effects in a notable way, it seems difficult to distinguish between them without multi-layered panel data. A different composition of an area, for example a higher number of people holding cosmopolitan attitudes in cities, can also lead to different experiences in these contexts, such as getting more in touch with cosmopolitan arguments or lifestyle. Or, in the words of Jennings and Stoker⁶⁵: “In short, context and self-selection work together to produce location effects”. With our data, we cannot make any causal claims about why people living in rural and urban places are different from one another and whether self-sorting or contextual effects are better at explaining these differences. Our approach is purely cross-sectional and aims to look at the distribution of today’s urban and rural populations, regardless of why they live there and whether they were different before they moved.

Conclusion

In recent years, scholars in the political sciences have shown a resurgent interest in the analysis of the rural-urban divide from different angles. Our contribution investigates the rural-urban divide of public preferences for democracy and its authoritarian alternatives. In addition to the mere evaluation of whether a rural-urban gap regarding regime preference exists, we try to uncover the mechanisms of this geographical divide. We argue that possible rural-urban differences are due to the differing socio-economic situation, different values or to the degree of political discontent of urbanites and rural dwellers.

Employing data from the EVS 2017–2020 with around 30,000 observations from 32 countries, we find a geography of autocracy: Compared to rural dwellers, people living in urban areas exhibit a stronger preference for democratic political systems as opposed to their authoritarian alternatives. Thus, our study confirms that citizens' support for democracy is somewhat rooted in geographical conditions. Moreover, our structural equation models indicate that this relationship is mainly mediated by a socio-economic and a cultural mechanism. A respondent's education, their concept of ethnic nationhood and their moral values in particular stand behind the spatial divide of regime preference. However, according to our empirical analyses, unequal political trust or political dissatisfaction between urban and rural dwellers are not driving forces with respect to spatial differences of regime preferences.

It should be noted, however, that our results are only a first step and do not exhaust the analysis of a spatial dimension of democratic principles. Although they point in the right direction, we need more studies that empirically examine the consequences of the rural-urban divide with regard to regime preferences and the support of democracy. As such, our approach has its limitations that require further attention.

First, we have to admit that our measurement of spatial divide is very crude. The degree of urbanization is based on the pure number of inhabitants. Even though this is a well-established measure of the rural-urban divide,⁶⁶ it disregards that urbanity can also be defined according to different, e.g. functional criteria or the duration of residence, and that the number of inhabitants alone is not a completely accurate dimension of urbanity.⁶⁷ In addition, with our indicators we can only insufficiently capture the place-based resentments and cannot exactly determine which of the perceived grievances are directly linked to the place of residence.⁶⁸ Second, as we only operate with cross-sectional data, we must underscore that future studies should empirically examine the causal mechanism between the rural-urban divide and political preferences in order to provide a more confident base to indeed speak of a causal relationship. In order to be able to make causal statements, a replication of this study with panel data would be necessary. Moreover, our study assumes that rural and urban respondents evaluate different political regimes according to their own socio-economic position and moral values. In this respect, we cannot determine whether the difference in population composition between urban and rural areas is due to geographical sorting or the influence of the distinct contexts.⁶⁹ Third, as the spatial divide does not affect the entire population in the same way, it is reasonable to assume that the effects of the rural-urban divide are not uniform. It would therefore be advisable to model group-specific geographical effects.

Nevertheless, our analysis indicates that not all groups are equally supportive of democracy and that socio-economic as well as cultural factors explain this relationship. It is important to understand these geographical differences in order to counteract democratic deconsolidation and to be able to specifically target political sub-groups in campaigns with relevant arguments. This alone justifies analyses such as the present one, even if it operates with the shortcomings outlined.

Notes

1. Lago, "Rural Decline and Satisfaction"; Mitsch, Lee, and Ralph-Morrow, "Faith no More?". With regard to political trust, Mitsch, Lee and Ralph-Morrow report that polarization

between urban and rural Europe has actually increased over the past decade. We find the same for democratic support in recent years (results are available upon request).

2. e.g. Cramer *The Politics of Resentment*; Dijkstra, Poelman, and Rodríguez-Pose, "The Geography of EU Discontent"; Harteveld, van der Brug, and de Lange, "Periphery, Not Rurality?"; Jennings and Stoker "The Bifurcation of Politics"; Kenny and Luca "The Rural-Urban Polarisation"; Lichter and Ziliak "The Rural-Urban Interface"; Maxwell "Cosmopolitan Immigration Attitudes"; McKay, Jennings, and Stoker "Political Trust in the 'Places That Don't Matter'"; Neal et al. "Rural Brexit?"; Scala and Johnson "Political Polarization Along the Rural-Urban Continuum?"
3. It should be noted that, building on Easton *A Framework for Political Analysis*, different types of diffuse and specific support can be identified. Thus, according to Dalton *Democratic Challenges, Democratic Choices* and Norris "The Conceptual Framework of Political Support", the concept of democratic support examined here must be analytically separated from political trust types as an approval of core regime principles and values. While the latter tends to the specific types of support, the concept analysed here is to be classified as diffuse support. Moreover, according to this conceptual clarification, satisfaction with democracy is to distinguish from democratic support, see Claassen, "Does Public Support Help Democracy Survive?".
4. Tajfel and Turner, "An Integrative Theory of Intergroup Conflict".
5. "Us Over Here Versus Them Over There," 1059.
6. Tajfel and Turner, "An Integrative Theory of Intergroup Conflict".
7. Norris, "The Conceptual Framework of Political Support".
8. "Democracy and Working-Class Authoritarianism".
9. *A Framework for Political Analysis*.
10. Claassen, "Does Public Support Help Democracy Survive?"
11. Kriesi et al. *West European Politics*; Lipset "Democracy and Working-Class Authoritarianism"; Rodríguez-Pose "The Revenge of the Places That Don't Matter".
12. "It's NOT the Economy, Stupid".
13. Malka et al., "Who is Open to Authoritarian Governance".
14. Cramer, *The Politics of Resentment*; Jacobs and Munis, "Place-Based Resentment in Contemporary US Elections".
15. Sarsfield and Echegaray, "Opening the Black Box".
16. Linz and Stepan, "Toward Consolidated Democracies"; Norris, "Is Western Democracy Backsliding?".
17. "The Signs of Deconsolidation".
18. "Democracy and Working-Class Authoritarianism".
19. *A Framework for Political Analysis*.
20. Claassen, "Does Public Support Help Democracy Survive?"; Dalton, *Democratic Challenges, Democratic Choices*; Foa and Mounk, "The Danger of Deconsolidation"; Foa and Mounk, "The Signs of Deconsolidation"; Inglehart, "The Danger of Deconsolidation"; Linz and Stepan, "Toward Consolidated Democracies"; Norris "Is Western Democracy Backsliding?"; Zilinsky, "Democratic Deconsolidation Revisited".
21. see for example Ceka and Magalhães, "Do the Rich and The Poor Have Different Conceptions of Democracy?"; Foa and Mounk, "The Danger of Deconsolidation"; Klingemann, Fuchs, and Zielonka, *Democracy and Political Culture*; Letsa and Wilfahrt, "Popular Support for Democracy"; Norris, "Is Western Democracy Backsliding?"; Zaslove et al., "Power to the People?"; Zilinsky, "Democratic Deconsolidation Revisited".
22. "Cleavage Structures, Party Systems, and Voter Alignments".
23. Hooghe and Marks, "Cleavage Theory Meets Europe's Crises"; Kriesi et al., *West European Politics in the Age of Globalization*.
24. Cramer, *The Politics of Resentment*; de Dominicis, Dijkstra, and Pontarollo, "The Rural-Urban Divide in Anti-EU Vote"; Deppisch, Osgus, and Klärner, "How Rural is Rural Populism?"; Jennings and Stoker, "The Bifurcation of Politics"; Jennings and Stoker, "The Divergent Dynamics of Cities and Towns"; Kenny and Luca, "The Rural-Urban Polarisation of Political Disenchantment"; Kelly and Lobal, "The Social Bases of Rural-Urban Political Divides"; Maxwell, "Cosmopolitan Immigration Attitudes"; Maxwell, "Geographic Divides and Cosmopolitanism"; Mitsch, Lee, and Ralph-Morrow, "Faith no More?"; Munis, "Us Over Here Versus Them Over There"; Neal et al. "Rural Brexit?"; Rodríguez-Pose, "The Revenge of the Places That

- Don't Matter"; Scala and Johnson, "Political Polarization Along the Rural-Urban Continuum?"; Schoene, "European Disintegration?"; Wuthnow, *The Left Behind*.
25. Tajfel and Turner, "An Integrative Theory of Intergroup Conflict".
 26. Munis, "Us Over Here Versus Them Over There," 1059.
 27. Kenny and Luca, "The Rural-Urban Polarisation of Political Disenchantment"; Mitsch, Lee, and Ralph-Morrow, "Faith no More?".
 28. Cramer, *The Politics of Resentment*; de Dominicis, Dijkstra, and Pontarollo, "The Rural-Urban Divide in Anti-EU Vote"; Deppisch, Osigus, and Klärner, "How Rural is Rural Populism?"; Kenny and Luca, "The Rural-Urban Polarisation of Political Disenchantment"; Mitsch, Lee, and Ralph-Morrow, "Faith no More?"; Rodríguez-Pose, "The Revenge of the Places That Don't Matter"; Schoene, "European Disintegration?"; Wuthnow, *The Left Behind*.
 29. e.g. Cramer, *The Politics of Resentment*; Gordon, "In What Sense Left Behind".
 30. Kaufmann, "It's NOT the Economy, Stupid"; Kelly and Lobao, "The Social Bases of Rural-Urban Political Divides"; Maxwell, "Cosmopolitan Immigration Attitudes"; Schoene, "European Disintegration?".
 31. Dijkstra, Poelman, and Rodríguez-Pose, "The Geography of EU Discontent"; Gordon, "In What Sense Left Behind"; Kriesi et al., *West European Politics in the Age of Globalization*; Maxwell, "Cosmopolitan Immigration Attitudes"; Scala and Johnson, "Political Polarization Along the Rural-Urban Continuum?"; Schoene, "European Disintegration?".
 32. Cramer, *The Politics of Resentment*; Przeworski, *Crises of Democracy*.
 33. Howe, "The Danger of Deconsolidation"; Lipset, "Democracy and Working-Class Authoritarianism". Such rhetoric is often used by populist-authoritarian parties that seek to appeal to the "losers" of globalization by promoting nativist values and skepticism towardss globalization, see Mudde and Kaltwasser, *Populism in Europe and the Americas*; Rooduijn, "The Rise of the Populist Radical Right".
 34. Kaufmann, "It's NOT the Economy, Stupid". Kaufmann investigates the UK 2016 Brexit vote and finds that rural-urban differences in the voting pattern are not primarily explained by the rural population feeling threatened in their socio-economic status and neglected with their material concerns, but rather that voting behavior is mainly explained by personal values.
 35. Cramer, *The Politics of Resentment*; Gordon, "In What Sense Left Behind"; Jennings and Stoker, "The Divergent Dynamics of Cities and Towns"; Maxwell, "Cosmopolitan Immigration Attitudes"; Mitsch, Lee, and Ralph-Morrow, "Faith no More?"; Schoene, "European Disintegration?"; Wuthnow, *The Left Behind*.
 36. "Who is Open to Authoritarian Governance".
 37. Cramer, *The Politics of Resentment*; Jacobs and Munis, "Place-Based Resentment in Contemporary US Elections"; Mitsch, Lee, and Ralph-Morrow, "Faith no More?"; Scala and Johnson, "Political Polarization Along the Rural-Urban Continuum?"; Schoene, "European Disintegration?"; Wuthnow, *The Left Behind*.
 38. Stein, Buck, and Bjørnå, "The Centre-Periphery Dimension and Trust in Politicians".
 39. Jacobs and Munis, "Place-Based Resentment in Contemporary US Elections".
 40. Sarsfield and Echegaray, "Opening the Black Box".
 41. EVS, "European Values Study 2017".
 42. Of the 34 countries in the EVS dataset, Great Britain and the Netherlands have to be excluded due to missing data.
 43. "National Identity Between Democracy and Autocracy".
 44. The democracy – autocracy preference scale has been established and has found increasing use in literature as a measure of diffuse support for democracy, see Erhardt, Wamsler, and Freitag, "National Identity Between Democracy and Autocracy". This scale is called a preference scale because it implicitly compares support for democracy with support for authoritarian alternatives, even though it does not directly measure an order of preference for different regimes. The EVS also includes the item d) having experts, not government, make decisions according to what they think is best for the country. However, as Erhardt, Wamsler, and Freitag "National Identity Between Democracy and Autocracy" we exclude this item from the analysis because expert rule can occur in democracies and need not necessarily be undemocratic.
 45. An exploratory factor analysis (not shown here) indicates that the items load onto a single factor (factor loadings: democracy 0.58, strong leader –0.80, army –0.80).

46. We are aware that the size of the town where the interview was conducted is only a proxy for urbanity. A small town could be located in between two large cities in a densely populated region. However, we are more interested in the rural-urban cleavage than in the center-periphery cleavage. The only alternative spatial data in the EVS are the NUTS regions, but we decided against them as they are too large and do not cover spatial differences accurately enough.
47. Nemerever and Rogers, "Measuring the Rural Continuum".
48. We re-calculated the regression models with alternative codings of the urbanity variable, i.e. dichotomous variables with varying cut-off values. This did not change our findings substantially (results are available upon request).
49. Kenny and Luca, "The Rural-Urban Polarisation of Political Disenchantment"; Maxwell, "Cosmopolitan Immigration Attitudes"; Maxwell, "Geographic Divides and Cosmopolitanism".
50. Cramer, *The Politics of Resentment*; Kaufmann, "It's NOT the Economy, Stupid"; Mitsch, Lee, and Ralph-Morrow, "Faith no More?"; Wuthnow, *The Left Behind*.
51. Even though authoritarianism might seem close to our dependent variable, it is empirically and conceptually distinct from attitudes towards democratic/authoritarian regimes, see Dunn "Enemies of Democracy?". In this regard authoritarianism can be defined as "social attitudinal or ideological expressions of basic social values or motivational goals that represent different, though related, strategies for attaining collective security at the expense of individual autonomy", see Duckitt and Bizumic, "Multidimensionality of Right-Wing Authoritarian Attitudes," 842.
52. An exploratory factor analysis (not shown here) indicates that the four items of moral values all load on a single factor with factor loadings of at least 0.74.
53. Cramer, *The Politics of Resentment*; Mitsch, Lee, and Ralph-Morrow, "Faith no More?"; Schoene, "European Disintegration?". Regrettably, indicators of political efficacy are not included in the EVS 2017–2020.
54. Kenny and Luca, "The Rural-Urban Polarisation of Political Disenchantment"; Maxwell, "Cosmopolitan Immigration Attitudes". We apply listwise deletion of missing data, as it is a preferred method for handling missing observations and offers more advantages than pairwise deletion, see Allison, *Missing Data*. This leads to a small bias in our sample compared to all respondents in the EVS. In this regard, comparing the values of the socio-demographic variables of the observations included in our regression models on the one hand and the excluded observations due to listwise deletion on the other, the deviations are nowhere greater than 23% of a standard deviation. The largest deviations are with regard to education, income and liberal values, with those in our sample being slightly more educated, and having higher incomes and more liberal values than in the EVS sample as a whole (each about 21–22% of a standard deviation). As the deviations between the included and the excluded observations are relatively small, we conduct listwise deletion.
55. Castanho Silva, Bosancianu, and Littvay, *Multilevel Structural Equation Modeling*.
56. We replicate our linear regression analysis for the difference method using regional-level fixed effects instead of country-level ones and find substantially the same results (see table A16 in the Supplemental Appendix). However, there is a large number of excluded regions due to missing values or a lack of variance in one or more of the main variables, which is why it is not possible to replicate the path analysis with regional fixed effects. Due to this systematic exclusion of certain regions, we opt for country-level fixed effects in the paper.
57. We also re-calculated the regression models including the squared self-placement on the political left-right scale (results available upon request). However, the coefficients were not statistically significant and did not change our results substantially, which is why we opted to leave the squared self-placement on the left-right scale out for our structural equation models.
58. The coefficients in our models indicate quite small effect sizes, which may cast doubt on the substantivity of the reported relationships. However, "as is the case with virtually any effect size, relatively small effect sizes may be substantively important, whereas relatively large ones may be trivial, depending on the research context", Preacher and Kelley, "Effect Size Measures for Mediation Models," 108. Especially considering our study works with observational data rather than experimentally manipulating or abstractly indexing it, even objectively small effect sizes can indicate important and substantial relationships.
59. Van Der Weele, "Mediation Analysis".

60. Table A1 in the Supplemental Appendix shows the results of Models 3–6 with the inclusion of our three controls sex, age and political left-right position. The controls do not change the results in a relevant way.
61. A structural equation model including all four items of the moral values index (not shown here) reveals that the justification of divorce and especially homosexuality are the strongest mediators, while the justification of abortion and particularly euthanasia have a lower explanatory power.
62. We re-calculated the full model separately for Eastern and Western Europe (see tables A14 and A15 in the Supplemental Appendix). Our results reveal mainly the same effects in Eastern and Western Europe. However, the total effect of urbanity is larger in Eastern Europe than in Western Europe, while the mediators explain a slightly larger part of the effect in Western Europe. Concerning the individual mediators, income only has a mediating effect in Eastern Europe. While the ethnic conception of nationhood is a stronger mediator in Western Europe, moral values are more important in Eastern Europe.
63. Maxwell, “Cosmopolitan Immigration Attitudes”; Maxwell, “Geographic Divides and Cosmopolitanism”.
64. Lago, “Rural Decline and Satisfaction with Democracy”; Maxwell, “Cosmopolitan Immigration Attitudes”; Maxwell, “Geographic Divides and Cosmopolitanism”.
65. “The Bifurcation of Politics,” 373.
66. Nemerever and Rogers, “Measuring the Rural Continuum”.
67. Beynon, Crawley, and Munday, “Measuring and Understanding the Differences”.
68. Cramer, *The Politics of Resentment*.
69. Bishop, *The Big Sort*.

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